

Resilient Schools Proposal Frequently Asked Questions

To provide additional clarity and build shared understanding, we've compiled responses to a number of the common questions and themes that we've heard following the release of the Resilient Schools Proposal on August 25, 2026. We will continue to update this page.

► Why is the district moving straight to closures instead of identifying schools for the community engagement phase as outlined in the Long Range Advisory Committee metrics?

At the **Oct. 21, 2025 worksession** (<https://go.boarddocs.com/co/bvsvd/Board.nsf/goto?open&id=DMARCL6D3835>), it became clear that too many schools would be approaching the engagement phase identified in the metrics at the same time to be able to conduct individual community engagement processes and that it would make more sense to take a regional approach toward taking action. The **LRAC metrics** (</fs/pages/34397>) call for taking a regional approach when appropriate.

The Board directed staff to look for a more comprehensive solution and set the following goals:

- Maintain and improve learning outcomes for all students
- Distribute students so all schools have the right level of students/resources to maintain high-quality learning experiences
- Stabilize overall enrollment by retaining current students and attracting new students to the district

to address ongoing fiscal challenges

Got a question? 🙋

that allowing schools to stay "small" was not a feasible option and

considered:

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grams

- Grade reconfiguration, e.g. convert a pair of elementary schools to K-2 & 3-5 or convert a pair of K-8s to elementary and middle
- Allocate focus programs
- Consolidate two or more schools into one building (existing or new)
- Close one or more schools and distribute students to multiple schools

The Board asked district leadership to engage with our community on the issue before developing specific recommendations. Earlier this year BVSD conducted an **extensive community engagement process** (<http://www.bvsd.org/current-topics/declining-enrollment/connect-with-us-on-this-important-topic>).

► **Please clarify how enrollment/placement would work for students who are open enrolled into impacted schools.**

Staff presented a draft open enrollment priority to the Board for consideration as part of the Resilient Schools proposal. **The Board will study this item further on Sept. 8.**

The following priority framework was proposed:

If your school is a neighborhood school and is closed, or is a focus school that moves to a new location:

- In-district students currently enrolled in the school will be placed in their new neighborhood school or continue with the school at its new location, or
- If you prefer another BVSD school you may apply through Open Enrollment and receive **first priority to a non-charter BVSD school in the lottery.**
- Out-of-district students must apply through Open Enrollment and will receive **first priority to a non-charter BVSD school in the lottery.**

Important to Know

- This priority is for the 2027–28 school year Open Enrollment process only.
- It applies only to students enrolled in the 2026-27 school year whose school has been closed or moved.

Got a question? 🙋 Will depend on available space, programming, and staffing.
not included in the new, one-year additional priority.

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► **Will school bell schedules change as part of this proposal?**

With the exception of Whittier, bell schedule decisions are not part of the Resilient Schools proposal. Final bell schedules will be determined after the Board takes action on the proposal on September 22. We will communicate any changes to families and staff once those decisions are finalized.

► **What will happen to school buildings that are no longer used as schools?**

Decisions about the future use of buildings are not part of the Resilient Schools proposal.

If the Board approves the proposal, the district will begin a separate process after Sept. 22 to explore future uses of affected facilities and sites.

► **Will receiving schools have enough room for the students and programs moving there?**

Yes. Building capacity and the space needed for students, classrooms and programs were considered in developing the recommendations.

In some cases where the new short term enrollment will push the school near capacity, enrollment projections take into account managing choice enrollment beginning in 2027-28 to ensure that resident students can be accommodated in the buildings.

In some buildings, existing spaces may need to be rearranged or used differently as schools prepare for the transition. During the transition year, the district will work with each receiving school to develop its specific open enrollment, space and staffing plan so that students can be accommodated within district class-size guidelines while preserving the spaces needed to support school programs.

Got a question? 🙋

building

ies achieved by closing schools, we will be able to reduce class sizes for
n the district, regardless of the overall capacity and utilization of a

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► **Why aren't changes to dual-language programs included in this proposal, and when will these decisions be made?**

Dual language programming remains a district priority, but, as shared in the proposal, we believe more study and community input are needed before making recommendations. The district sees opportunities to strengthen dual language programming in both Boulder and Lafayette, including student outcomes, continuity from elementary to middle school, consistency of middle school course offerings, and attainment of the Seal of Biliteracy.

During our community engagement this spring, we had one session fully in Spanish at Columbine, and had 60 people attending and 39 questionnaires collected. Given this relatively limited feedback, the proposal is to conduct a deeper review of our PK–5 and 6–8 dual language models during the 2026–27 school year. This will include internal review, national research, and dedicated feedback sessions with dual language teachers and families. That work will inform future recommendations about dual language programming. A proposal will be brought back to the Board of Education at a date to be determined.

► **How are you improving equity of access to focus schools?**

The district plans to provide transportation for income-qualifying families attending focus schools across BVSD. Currently, transportation is available for qualifying students attending Community Montessori, Pioneer and University Hill, but not for students attending BCSIS or High Peaks. As part of this work, the district plans to address that inconsistency so eligible families at all focus schools can have transportation. Additional details about eligibility and implementation will be developed as part of the district's transition planning.

► **Why isn't school performance being considered?**

School performance is not a driver of this process because BVSD schools are performing at historically high levels. The challenge is not school quality, it is fewer school age children living in the declining area and the impact that has on resources and programming.

Got a question? 🙋

► **Will preschool programming continue to be offered in affected regions?**

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Yes. Specific preschool locations for the 2027-28 school year will be shared by Oct. 1.

Families who have a returning preschooler will receive enrollment and transition information before preschool registration opens for the 27-28 school year.

► **Will the preschool program move with Community Montessori to its new location? Will there be enough room for both schools to use the gym?**

Preschool is an essential part of Montessori programming. If the Board approves the Resilient Schools proposal on Sept. 22, district staff will work with a project team to renovate spaces in the BCSIS/High Peaks building to accommodate all preschool needs. Additionally, conversations about how common spaces in the building would be used by both schools would be part of the transition planning over the next year.

► **How are the impacts to middle school feeder patterns being taken into account?**

Staff realizes that changes at the elementary level will affect the articulation paths for students through middle and high school. These impacts can be evaluated as part of a future boundary analysis.

► **Will there be room in School Age Care (SAC) programs at receiving schools?**

We understand SAC is essential for many families and it will be offered at all receiving schools. At schools where there is high demand for the program, we are investigating the possibility of expanding. Our ability to do so is limited by state-mandated staffing ratios and space requirements.

The SAC lottery occurs in the spring. More information about availability will be provided at that time. Students currently enrolled in a SAC program will receive returning student status

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Community Engagement Process FAQ Archive

Below is an archive of questions that came from our community during the Community Engagement Sessions earlier this year.

► **Boulder County is growing. How is it possible that we have fewer kids?**

An important consideration when looking at county population data is that BVSD only occupies the southern two-thirds of Boulder County and does not include the large growing community of Longmont, which greatly skews population growth in County estimates. When looking at the major population centers within BVSD, the story is different. Although long-term projections at the municipal level aren't readily available, most of these population centers have shown stagnant or declining populations between 2020 and 2024 according to State Demographer estimates. Only Lafayette and Erie had some growth over that timeframe with only Erie having significant growth.

When we look at data specific to BVSD, several trends stand out. Most prominent is that population growth is not equal for all age groups. When comparing the 2010 and 2020 Census population for BVSD, the largest growth segment is those residents aged 60 and above, with some growth among young adults (impacted by CU enrollment expansions). However, the population of children under 10 years old has shrunk by over 1,600 people, which is a trend expected to continue as the number of births remains very low. The average number of births per woman (Total Fertility Rate) also declined from 1.4 children per woman to 1.0 during that time frame. While student-aged populations are in decline, the growing population above 60 is expected to further constrain housing turnover and opportunities for people with children to find suitable housing within BVSD.

► **How can BVSD say it lacks resources when property taxes are high?**

Got a question? 🗣️

potential local tax revenue—but that doesn't mean the district has unlimited money to spend. In Colorado, school funding is based on a state formula, not just property taxes.

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many students a district serves. So when enrollment declines too. Fewer students = fewer dollars for teachers, staff, and programs. Even if property taxes go up due to increasing property values, that doesn't automatically give the district more flexible funding. In fact, the system works in a way that can feel counterintuitive: When local property tax revenue increases due to increasing property values, the state often contributes less. Therefore, overall funding doesn't necessarily rise accordingly. At the same time, many costs don't shrink as quickly as enrollment—there are still buildings to operate and systems and staff needed to support the students still in the building.

So even in a community with high property taxes, declining enrollment means fewer resources to support the same system, unless changes are made. Voter approved local property tax increases for operating costs are capped by state statute, and BVSD voters have generously approved the maximum amount allowed. Property taxes for capital construction debt is also approved locally. Property taxes increase to pay those annual principal and interest costs in accordance with the approved ballot language. In summary, property taxes can increase due to rising property values and locally approved tax increases. Rising property taxes don't necessarily provide additional operating dollars to cover costs that increase with inflation, contracts and statutory requirements.

► **Can we fundraise the money needed to keep schools open?**

Fundraising is not a sustainable solution for addressing declining enrollment or keeping schools open long term. The financial impact of under-enrolled schools is significant and ongoing. It includes staffing, building operations, and the full range of services required to run a school. These are sizable, recurring, structural costs that would need to be covered year after year. Relying on fundraising to sustain schools would create inequities across the district and would not provide the long-term stability needed to ensure a high-quality experience for all students. Our responsibility is to make decisions that are sustainable, equitable, and reliable over time, so every student, in every school, has access to the resources and opportunities they need to succeed.

► **Why isn't school performance being considered?**

School performance is not a driver of this process because BVSD schools are performing at historically high levels. The challenge is not school quality, it is fewer school age children living in the district and surrounding area and the impact that has on resources and programming.

Got a question? 🙋

► **How can we attract students back from private schools and homeschooling?**

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steps to attract and retain students, including expanding programming, increasing transparency in its enrollment process, hosting district-wide showcases, and offering enrollment preferences for families who work within the boundaries of the district. These efforts have helped. In fact, nearly 10% of BVSD's current students open-enrolled into our schools from neighboring districts. However, we know that some families will

always prefer private schools or homeschooling. Declining enrollment in BVSD is due to declining birth rates coupled with the high-cost and low inventory of single-family housing, not failing schools.

► **What will happen to school buildings that are closed?**

No decisions have been made about specific buildings. This will be determined as part of the later planning phases and Board decisions.

► **Why aim for fuller schools if BVSD already has strong academic outcomes?**

The goal is not simply to fill buildings—it is to ensure schools have sufficient enrollment to sustain programming, staffing, and student supports. When enrollment declines, schools may lose access to full-time specialists, collaborative teaching teams, and consistent programming. School leaders, teachers, and school staff are working very hard to support student learning despite declining resources. However, this level of effort is not sustainable, and it will only get harder as enrollment continues to decline. Maintaining adequate enrollment helps preserve the quality of the student experience.

► **How is the district considering communities impacted by the Marshall Fire?**

The district recognizes the impact of the Marshall Fire both related to enrollment and emotional trauma. At this time, data indicates that families who were relocated due to the fire have returned if they were inclined to do so and that enrollment in the area has normalized related to the temporary shifts due to the fire.

We realize that the disruption of school consolidations or closures will be difficult for families more so for members of our BVSD community who experienced the Marshall Fire. We are mindful of supporting the various needs of our community through transition and this will be an important part of our work.

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► **How is the district considering affordability as a driver of enrollment decline?**

Housing affordability is a major factor influencing enrollment and is largely outside the district's direct control. The district is engaging with municipalities and regional partners to better understand and align around long-term planning, but demographic and housing trends remain a broader community challenge.

► **Why are there no listening sessions in Nederland? Will mountain schools be closed?**

Due to their unique geographic circumstances, mountain schools require differentiated decisions and are not part of the current process.

► **What has the district learned from families who have left BVSD?**

The district has learned that families make choices for a variety of reasons, including convenience of school locations, specific family needs, preference for alternative education models, online learning, or preference for private schools. Since the pandemic, interest in these options has increased. At the same time, BVSD continues to attract nearly twice as many students than it loses to surrounding districts.

► **How will equity be considered in decisions about school closures?**

Equity is a foundational value in BVSD and will be a key consideration in developing options. The district is engaging broadly with the community to understand impacts and priorities, with a focus on ensuring that decisions support strong outcomes and access to resources for all students. The engagement process has been intentionally designed to encourage participation and allow all voices to be heard. When needed, we are providing tailored opportunities for input to school communities that have not felt comfortable participating in the scheduled engagement

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► **What about the impact on students when schools consolidate, and how will they be mitigated?**

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The district recognizes that transitions can be challenging. The goal is to ensure that, over time, students have access to more consistent programming, more options for friends and social connections, and more robust support services. Transition planning and support for students and families will be part of implementation. Planning for a thoughtful and well supported transition will be part of the work of developing options.

► **Will larger schools lead to larger class sizes?**

No—larger schools do not necessarily mean larger class sizes. What larger schools provide is more students per grade level, which allows the district to distribute students across more teachers. This often leads to more consistent class sizes, not bigger ones. In smaller schools with only one or two classes per grade, even small changes in enrollment can significantly increase class size in a single classroom. Larger schools create more flexibility to balance class sizes and absorb those changes more smoothly.

Due to the efficiencies of the Resilient Schools proposal, BVSD will be able to reduce class sizes in all elementary schools.

► **How will BVSD ensure decisions are not driven only by the loudest voices?**

We are intentionally designing this process so decisions are not driven by the loudest voices. We are gathering input in multiple ways—small group discussions, surveys, and polling—to make sure we hear from a broad cross-section of our community, including people who may not typically speak up publicly. We recognize that some individuals or groups may try to amplify their perspectives through emails, public comment, or organized outreach. We see and value that input, but it will not be what drives our decisions. Our goal is to understand the collective values and priorities of the entire community and use that to inform thoughtful, balanced decisions.

Got a question? 🙋

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